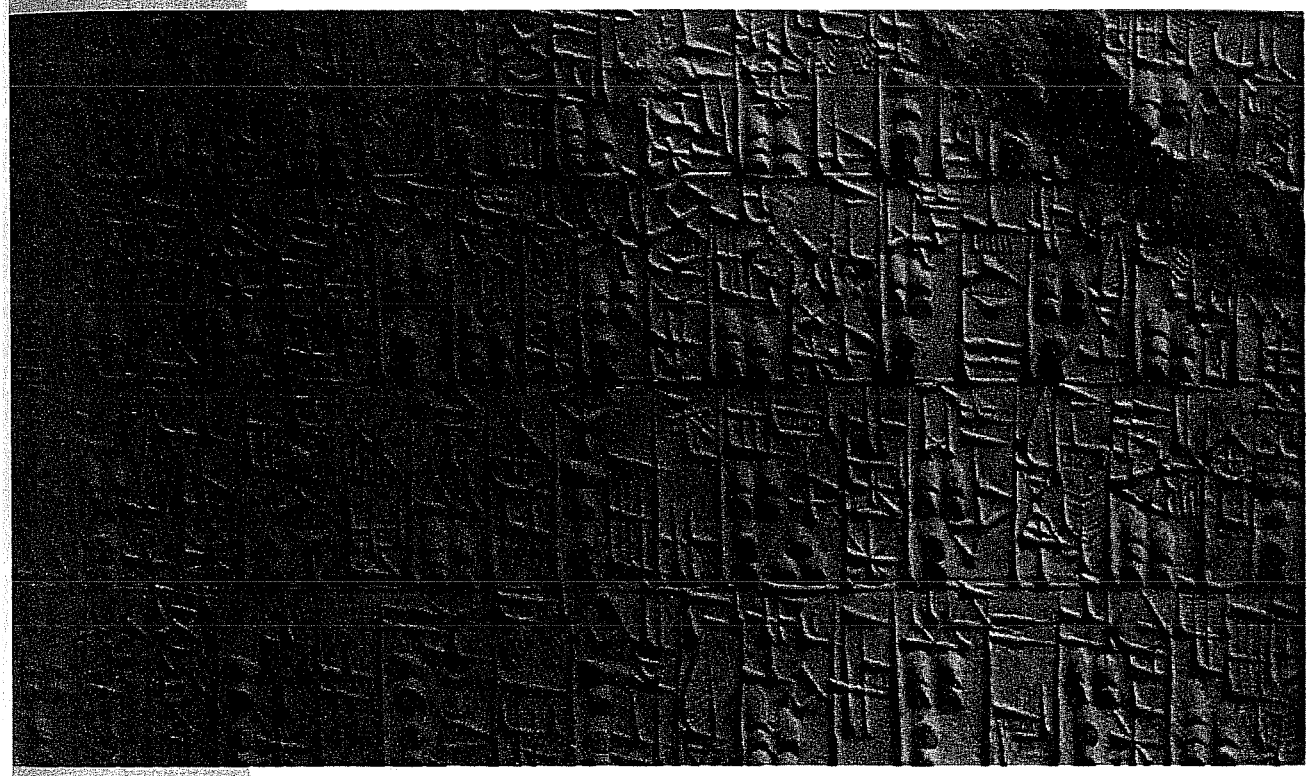
CHAPTER

8 Paraphrase and Summary



Sumerian cuneiform

Academic writing normally requires that you support your ideas and opinions with facts, statistics, quotations, and similar kinds of information. There are four ways to use information from outside sources. You can quote it directly or indirectly, skills that you practiced in Chapter 3. You can also **paraphrase** or **summarize** it, skills that you will practice in this chapter. Writing paraphrases and summaries are important tools in academic writing.

Paraphrasing

When you paraphrase, you rewrite information from an outside source in your own words without changing the meaning. Because you include in your rewriting all or nearly all of the content of the original passage, a paraphrase is almost as long as the original. (A summary, by contrast, is much shorter than the original.)

MODEL

Paraphrase

Original Passage

Language is the main means of communication between peoples. But so many different languages have developed that language has often been a barrier rather than an aid to understanding among peoples. For many years, people have dreamed of setting up an international universal language which all people could speak and understand. The arguments in favor of a universal language are simple and obvious. If all peoples spoke the same tongue, cultural and economic ties might be much closer, and good will might increase between countries (Kispert).[1]

Paraphrase

Humans communicate through language. Because there are so many different languages, however, people around the world have a difficult time understanding one another. Some people have wished for a universal international language that speakers all over the world could understand. Their reasons are straightforward and clear. A universal language would build cultural and economic bonds. It would also create better feelings among countries (Kispert).

Writing Technique Questions

1. How many sentences are there in the original passage? In the paraphrase?
2. Compare the original passage and the paraphrase sentence by sentence. Analyze how the sentence structure and words differ by answering the following questions.
   a. What is the first word of the first sentence in the original passage? Where does this word appear in first sentence of the paraphrase?
   b. What is the first word of the second sentence in the original passage? What word replaces it in the second sentence of the paraphrase?
   c. What words replace *have dreamed of* in the third sentence? What word replaces *arguments in favor of* in the fourth sentence?
   d. Which sentence in the original becomes two sentences in the paraphrase?

Plagiarism

It is important to learn how to use information from outside sources without committing plagiarism. *Plagiarism* is wrongly using someone else's words or ideas, and it is a serious offense. Students who plagiarize may fail a class or even be expelled from school.

There are two kinds of plagiarism.

1. When you use information from an outside source *without citing the source* (telling where you got the information), you are guilty of plagiarism.
2. Even when you cite your source, *if your paraphrase is too similar to the original*, you are guilty of plagiarism.

[1]Kispert, Robert J. "Universal language." World Book Online Reference Center. 2004. World Book, Inc. 13 Nov. 2004 <http://www.worldbookonline.com/wb/Article?id=ar576960>.

Read the following paraphrases and decide which kind of plagiarism each example is guilty of.

MODEL
Plagiarism

Unacceptable Paraphrase 1

Humans communicate through language. However, because there are so many languages in the world, language acts as an obstacle instead of as an aid to understanding. People have long wished for a universal international language that speakers all over the world could understand. A universal language would certainly build cultural and economic bonds. It would also create better feelings among countries.

Unacceptable Paraphrase 2

Language is the principal means of communication between peoples. However, because there are numerous languages, language itself has frequently been a barrier rather than an aid to understanding among the world population. For many years, people have envisioned a common universal language that everyone in the world could communicate in. The reasons for having a universal language are clearly understandable. If the same tongue were spoken by all countries, they would undoubtedly become closer culturally and economically. It would probably also create good will among nations (Kispert).

Paraphrase 1 is plagiarism because the source is not cited. Paraphrase 2 is plagiarism because it is too similar to the original passage. For example, in the first sentence, only one word has been changed: *main* replaces *principal*. In the second sentence, only a few words have been changed. You can avoid the first kind of plagiarism by always citing your sources. You can avoid the second kind of plagiarism by learning to paraphrase correctly.

See Appendix E: Research and Documentation of Sources, pages 303–311, for information on how to cite sources.

How to Write a Good Paraphrase

There are three keys to writing a good paraphrase:

1. Use your own words and your own sentence structure.
2. Make your paraphrase approximately the same length as the original.
3. Do not change the meaning of the original.

You can write a good paraphrase if you follow these steps.

Step 1 Read the original passage several times until you understand it fully. Look up unfamiliar words, and find synonyms for them. It may not be possible to find synonyms for every word, especially technical vocabulary. In this case, use the original word.

Step 2 It helps to take notes. Write down only a few words for each idea—not complete sentences. Here are one writer's notes on the original passage about universal language:

> language—people use to communicate—but so many—difficult to understand one another—people wish—universal international language—reasons: cultural, economic bonds, better feelings between countries

It may be helpful to make a brief outline such as the following:

A. Language—people use to communicate
1. So many languages make it difficult to understand one another.
2. People wish for one universal international language.

B. Reasons
1. Cultural, economic bonds
2. Better feelings between countries

Step 3 Write your paraphrase from your notes. Don't look at the original while you are writing.

Step 4 Check your paraphrase against the original to make sure you have not copied vocabulary or the sentence structure too closely. Above all, make sure that you have not changed the meaning of the original or given any wrong information.

Step 5 Add an in-text citation at the end.

PRACTICE 1

Choosing the Best Paraphrase

Step 1 Read the original passages.
Step 2 Choose the best paraphrase from the choices given and mark it "Best."
Step 3 Mark the others "Too sim." for too similar, "No cit." if there is no in-text citation, or "Inc./Inacc." for incomplete and/or inaccurate information.

The first one has been done for you as an example.

Original Passage 1

Source: Page 16 of a three-page article in the October 15, 2003, issue of *Space Science* magazine. The title of the article is "Manned Mars Flight: Impossible Dream?" The author is Patrick Clinton, a NASA (National Aeronautics and Space Administration) physician.

Living aboard a space station in orbit around Earth for months at a time poses problems for astronauts' bodies as well as for their minds.

Best **A.** An article in *Space Science* magazine reports that lengthy space station duty may lead to physical and mental problems for astronauts (Clinton 16).

No cit. **B.** An article in *Space Science* magazine reports that astronauts who live aboard space stations for long periods of time may experience physical as well as mental problems.

Too sim. **C.** An article in *Space Science* reports that living in a space station orbiting Earth for a long time can cause difficulties for astronauts' bodies and minds (Clinton 16).

Inc./Inacc. **D.** An article in *Space Science* reports that astronauts will become physically sick and have mental problems if they visit a space station (Clinton 16).

Original Passage 2

Source: Page 16 of the same article in passage 1.

One major problem is maintaining astronauts' physical health. Medical treatment may be days or even weeks away, as there may not be a doctor on board. Illnesses such as appendicitis or ulcers, routinely treated on Earth, could be fatal in space because of the delay in getting to a doctor.

_____ **A.** NASA physician Patrick Clinton states that one problem is astronauts' physical health. With no doctor on board, common illnesses like appendicitis and ulcers could be fatal to astronauts because it would take too long to get them back to Earth.

_____ **B.** NASA physician Patrick Clinton states that keeping the astronauts physically healthy is one problem. If the crew does not include a doctor, the delay in getting treatment for an ordinary illness, such as appendicitis or ulcers, could mean death (16).

_____ **C.** NASA physician Patrick Clinton states that the physical health of astronauts is a huge problem. Spaceships do not usually have medical doctors among the crew, so astronauts who get appendicitis on a long space journey will die (16).

_____ **D.** NASA physician Patrick Clinton states that one big problem is keeping astronauts in good physical health. Medical treatment might take days or weeks to get because there may not be a doctor on the spaceship. Ordinary illnesses such as appendicitis and ulcers could be deadly because it would take too long to get to a doctor (16).

Original Passage 3

Source: Page 17 of the same article as in passages 1 and 2.

Another health problem is the potential for bone deterioration. In a weightless environment, the body produces less calcium. Astronauts must exercise at least three hours a day to prevent bone loss.

_____ **A.** Another problem is the possibility of bone loss, according to NASA physician Patrick Clinton. In weightless space, the body makes less calcium. Astronauts have to exercise a minimum of three hours a day to avoid losing bone (17).

_____ **B.** According to NASA physician Patrick Clinton, weight can be a problem. Astronauts must take extra calcium and exercise at least three hours a day to keep from gaining weight and to prevent bone damage (17).

_____ **C.** According to NASA physician Patrick Clinton, astronauts could suffer bone loss. Being weightless causes the body to lose calcium, which is important for strength, so exercising at least three hours daily is necessary to keep their bones strong.

_____ **D.** According to NASA physician Patrick Clinton, astronauts also face possible bone loss. Because weightlessness causes the body to lose calcium, exercising at least three hours daily is necessary to keep their bones strong (17).

PRACTICE 2

Writing Paraphrases

Write a paraphrase of each of the passages that follow.

Step 1 Read the original passage several times until you understand it well. You may find it helpful to underline the main points.

Step 2 Make notes in the space provided, changing vocabulary words wherever possible.

Step 3 Write your paraphrase in your own words. Remember to change both vocabulary and sentence structure.

Step 4 Check your paraphrase to make sure you have not changed the meaning of the original passage.

Step 5 Add an in-text citation in the proper form at the end of each paraphrase.

Step 6 If your instructor requests, prepare an entry for a works-cited list for each source.

Original Passage 1

Source: Page 18 of a three-page article in the October 15, 2003, issue of *Space Science* magazine. The title of the article is "Manned Mars Flight: Impossible Dream?" The author is Patrick Clinton, a NASA physician.

A second major problem is maintaining astronauts' mental health. Being confined for long periods of time in dark and hostile space undoubtedly produces anxiety. Loneliness and boredom are other psychological concerns.

ɔtes

ɔur Paraphrase

riginal Passage 2

ɔurce: Page 18 of the same article as in passage 1.

nally, how can astronauts "let off steam" when interpersonal conflicts develop? ⁄en best friends can irritate each other when forced to spend weeks together in ɔlation. Space stations are small, cramped, busy workplaces, and there is little ·ivacy. Also, space exploration is dangerous, which adds to the stress aboard spaceship.

ɔtes

ɔur Paraphrase

Original Passage 3

Source: A Letter to the Editor written by Cory Brunish, which appeared on page 9 of the February 16, 2004, issue of *Time* magazine.

Why should we spend vast amounts to reach Mars when there is a very high chance of its not providing anything that would improve our lot here on Earth? Why not allocate those billions for "home improvement"? Think of the progress that could be made in curing cancer, AIDS, and other diseases; in cleaning our water, air, and soil; and in feeding hungry nations. Why confront the hazards of outer space when we should be fighting homelessness, poverty, and unemployment on Earth?

Notes

Your Paraphrase

Original Passage 4

Source: Page 48 of a nine-page magazine article written by Jeffrey Kluger. The article appeared on pages 42–50 in the January 26, 2004, issue of *Time* magazine. The title of the article is "Mission to Mars: First the Rover Lands, and Now Bush Wants to Send People. We Can Do It Even Faster Than Planned, but Here Is What It Will Take."

Speed is everything on the way to Mars and not only because a seven-month trip in a confined space can be torturous. The bigger problem is that it can be lethal because of radiation exposure in deep space, where the absence of Earth's magnetic field leaves astronauts far more exposed to deadly cosmic energy than they are in orbit or on the way to the moon.

Notes

Your Paraphrase

Using Paraphrases as Support

The purpose of learning to paraphrase is to be able to use paraphrases as supporting material in your writing. As you read the following model, notice how a student in a media studies class used a paraphrase of a passage from an online news article to support her idea.

MODEL

Using Paraphrases as Support

Original Passage

Source: Paragraph 2 of an article written by Kivi Leroux in the online magazine *E Magazine* titled "Subliminal Messages: Primetime TV Programs Educate Viewers on the Environment." It appeared in the "Currents" section of the July–August 1999 edition.

For 10 years, the Environmental Media Association (EMA) has been working to weave the environment into prime-time television programming. Created by and for professionals in the entertainment industry, EMA works with the stars in front of the cameras as well as the creative staff behind them to include environmental themes in scripts, show environmental products on sets, and make environmentally sound decisions in the studios.

Paraphrase

According to an article in *E Magazine*, environmental messages have been deliberately put into prime-time television shows for the past decade. Environmental Media Association, an organization of professionals in the entertainment business, encourages television actors, writers, directors, and producers to promote environmentalism in three ways: by using environmental issues in scripts, by using environmental products as props, and by making environmentally conscious choices in studios (Leroux, par. 2).

Writing Topic

Television programming in the United States is often criticized for promoting the wrong values. Do you agree or disagree with this criticism?

Completed Paragraph

Although it is sometimes true that television programming in the United States promotes the wrong values, I do not entirely agree. Many educational television channels promote good values. For example, the Discovery Channel, the History Channel, National Geographic, and other similar channels educate the public about science, history, nature, and the environment. Also, even prime-time television programming often provides a public service by spreading public service messages. In fact, environmental messages have been deliberately put into prime-time television shows for the past decade. Environmental Media Association, an organization of professionals in the entertainment business, encourages television actors, writers, directors, and producers to promote environmentalism in three ways: by using environmental issues in scripts, by using environmental products as props, and by making environmentally conscious choices in studios (Leroux, par. 2). Seeing the star of a prime-time television show recycling plastic bottles or using an environmentally friendly product is more persuasive than almost any other type of public service message. In short, television programs promote positive values in both direct and indirect ways.

PRACTICE 3
Using Paraphrases as Support

Some people feel that we should not send a manned spacecraft to Mars. Write a paragraph in which you agree with this statement.

Step 1 Write a topic sentence that states your opinion.
Step 2 Write several supporting sentences, using paraphrases that you wrote in Practice 2 (pages 132–134) to support your points. Include some additional supporting sentences and transition signals to connect the ideas and make your paragraph flow smoothly.
Step 3 Add an in-text citation at the end of each paraphrase you use.

Summarizing

Another way to use borrowed information from an outside source is to summarize it. What is the difference between a paraphrase and a summary? When you retell a story that someone has told you, you repeat the story in your own words. If your retelling is about the same length as the original, it is a paraphrase. If you shorten the story—retelling only the most important points and leaving out the details—it is a summary.

MODEL
Paraphrase and Summary

Original Passage (85 words)

Language is the main means of communication between peoples. But so many different languages have developed that language has often been a barrier rather than an aid to understanding among peoples. For many years, people have dreamed of setting up an international universal language which all people could speak and understand. The arguments in favor of a universal language are simple and obvious. If all peoples spoke the same tongue, cultural and economic ties might be much closer, and good will might increase between countries (Kispert).

Paraphrase (63 words, about the same length as the original)

Humans communicate through language. Because there are so many different languages, however, people around the world have a difficult time understanding one another. Some people have wished for a universal international language that speakers all over the world could understand. Their reasons are straightforward and clear. A universal language would build cultural and economic bonds. It would also create better feelings among countries (Kispert).

Summary (28 words, much shorter)

People communicate through language; however, having different languages creates communication barriers. A universal language could bring countries together culturally and economically as well as increase good feelings among them (Kispert).

Writing Technique Questions

1. How many sentences are there in the original passage? In the paraphrase? In the summary?
2. Compare the paraphrase and the summary. What two details were left out of the summary?

How to Write a Good Summary

There are three keys to writing a good summary:

1. Use your own words and your own sentence structure.
2. Remember that a summary is much shorter than a paraphrase. Include only the main points and main supporting points, leaving out most details.
3. Do not change the meaning of the original.

PRACTICE 4
Choosing the Best Summary

Read the original passage and the two summaries that follow it. Then answer these questions.

1. Which of the two is the better summary? Why?
2. Which summary contains an idea that was not in the original? Which sentence expresses this added idea?

Original Passage

Source: The following passage is excerpted from a newspaper article written by Marc Lacey. It appeared on page A3 of the *New York Times* on November 12, 2004. The title of the article is "Using a New Language in Africa to Save Dying Ones."

Swahili speakers wishing to use a "compyuta"—as *computer* is rendered in Swahili—have been out of luck when it comes to communicating in their tongue. Computers, no matter how bulky their hard drives or sophisticated their software packages, have not yet mastered Swahili or hundreds of other indigenous African languages.

But that may soon change. Across the continent, linguists are working with experts in information technology to make computers more accessible to Africans who happen not to know English, French, or the other major languages that have been programmed into the world's desktops.

There are economic reasons for the outreach. Microsoft, which is working to incorporate Swahili into Microsoft Windows, Microsoft Office, and other popular programs, sees a market for its software among the roughly 100 million Swahili speakers in East Africa. The same goes for Google, which last month launched www.google.co.ke, offering a Kenyan version in Swahili of the popular search engine.

But the campaign to Africanize cyberspace is not all about the bottom line. There are hundreds of languages in Africa—some spoken only by a few dozen elders—and they are dying out at an alarming rate. The continent's linguists see the computers as one important way of saving them. UNESCO estimates that 90 percent of the world's 6,000 languages are not represented on the Internet and that one language disappears somewhere around the world every two weeks.

Summary A

People who speak Swahili who want to communicate using a "compyuta," which is the Swahili word for computer, are unable to do so in their own language. It makes no difference that computers have huge hard drives and sophisticated software. They cannot operate in Swahili or other African languages, of which there are hundreds. Soon, however, they may be able to. Linguists in Africa are working with information technology specialists to make computers operable to Africans who do not know any of the languages currently used on the Internet. Economics is bringing about this change. Microsoft sees a market for its software among Swahili speakers in East Africa. Google now has a search engine for speakers of Swahili in Kenya. Other software companies will probably soon develop products for African consumers. In addition to economics, there is another reason for making the computer accessible to Africans. Hundreds of African languages are dying out, and linguists view the computer as a way to save them. According to UNESCO estimates, 90 percent of the world's 6,000 languages are not on the Internet, and one language becomes extinct every day somewhere in the world. The hope is that computers can help save them (Lacey).

Summary B

Many Africans who do not speak any of the major languages on the Internet have been unable to use computers in their native languages. Computers cannot yet accommodate languages such as Swahili. However, that situation may soon change. Linguists and computer experts are working to develop computers that work in Swahili and other African languages. Economics is one reason for doing so. Computer companies such as Microsoft and Google see a potentially huge market for its products in Africa. Another important reason is to save languages that are in danger of becoming extinct (Lacey).

The steps for writing a summary are similar to those for writing a paraphrase.

Step 1 Read the original passage several times until you understand it fully. Look up any words that you don't understand.

Step 2 Decide what the important ideas are. It helps to underline important ideas. It also helps to take notes. Write down only a few words for each idea—not complete sentences.

Step 3 Write your summary from your notes. Don't look at the original while you are writing.

Step 4 Check your summary against the original to make sure you have not changed the meaning.

Step 5 Add an in-text citation at the end of the summary.

PRACTICE 5

Writing Summaries

Write a one-paragraph summary of each of the following passages.

Step 1 Read the original passage several times until you understand it well. You may find it helpful to underline the main points.

Step 2 Make notes in the space provided, changing vocabulary words wherever possible.

Step 3 Write a summary of each passage in your own words.

Step 4 Add an in-text citation at the end of each summary.

Original Passage 1

Source: Various paragraphs of a news article written by Randolph E. Schmid. It was published online by the Associated Press on February 26, 2004. The title of the article is "Share of people who are native English speakers declining." The article is 25 paragraphs long. The Web site address is <http://pqasb.pqarchiver.com/ap/571281251.html?did=571281251&FMT=ABS&FMTS=FT&date=Feb+26%2C+2004&author=RANDOLPH+E.+SCHMID&desc=Share+of+people+who+are+native+English+speakers+declining.

The world faces a future of people speaking more than one language, with English no longer seen as likely to become dominant, a British language expert says in a new analysis. "English is likely to remain one of the world's most important languages for the foreseeable future, but its future is more problematic—and complex—than most people appreciate," said language researcher David Graddol (Schmid, pars. 1–2).

He sees English as likely to become the "first among equals" rather than having the global field to itself (par. 3). . . . The share of the world's population that speaks English as a native language is falling, Graddol reports in a paper in Friday's issue of the journal *Science* (par. 5).

"There is a distinct consciousness in many countries, both developed and developing, about this dominance of English. There is some evidence of resistance to it, a desire to change it" said [Scott] Montgomery [the author of another article published in the same issue of *Science*]. For example, he said, in the early years of the Internet it was dominated by sites in English, but in recent years there has been a proliferation of non-English sites, especially Spanish, German, French, Japanese, and others (pars. 19–20).

Nonetheless, English is strong as a second language, and teaching it has become a growth industry, said Montgomery, a Seattle-based geologist and energy consultant (par. 21).

Graddol noted, though, that employers in parts of Asia are already looking beyond English. "In the next decade the new 'must learn' language is likely to be Mandarin" (par. 22).

Notes

Summary

Original Passage 2

Source: Paragraphs 1 and 2 from a December 20, 2001, online article entitled "A world empire by other means." The author's name is not given. It was published on Economist.com, the Web site of a British magazine. The Web site address is <http://www.economist.com/displaystory.cfm?story_id=S%26%2BXL%2FRA%5F%24%0A>

It [English] is everywhere. Some 380 million people speak it as their first language and perhaps two-thirds as many again as their second. A billion are learning it, about a third of the world's population are in some sense exposed to it, and by 2050, it is predicted, half the world will be more or less proficient in it. It is the language of globalization—of international business, politics, and diplomacy. It is the language of computers and the Internet. You'll see it on posters in Côte d'Ivoire, you'll hear it in pop songs in Tokyo, you'll read it in official documents in Phnom Penh. Deutsche Welle broadcasts in it. Bjork, an Icelander, sings in it. French business schools teach in it. It is the medium of expression in cabinet meetings in Bolivia. Truly, the tongue spoken back in the 1300s only by the "low people" of England, as Robert of Gloucester put it at the time, has come a long way. It is now the global language.

How come? Not because English is easy. True, genders are simple, since English relies on "it" as the pronoun for all inanimate nouns, reserving masculine for bona fide males and feminine for females (and countries and ships). But the verbs tend to be irregular, the grammar bizarre, and the match between spelling and pronunciation a nightmare. English is now so widely spoken in so many places that umpteen versions have evolved, some so peculiar that even "native" speakers may have trouble understanding each other. But if only one version existed, that would present difficulties enough. Even everyday English is a language of subtlety, nuance, and complexity. John Simmons, a language consultant for Interbrand, likes to cite the word "set," an apparently simple word that takes on different meanings in a sporting, cooking, social, or mathematical context—and that is before any little words are combined with it. Then, as a verb, it becomes "set aside," "set up," "set down," "set in," "set on," "set about," "set against," and so on, terms that "leave even native speakers bewildered about [its] core meaning."

Notes

Summary

PRACTICE 6
Using Summaries as Support

Some people say that English is easy to learn, but difficult to master. Write a paragraph in which you agree with this statement.

Step 1 Begin with a clear topic sentence.
Step 2 Support your topic sentence with a summary—or a part of a summary—that you wrote in Practice 5. If you wish, include examples from your own knowledge and experience.
Step 3 Add an in-text citation at the end of each piece of summarized information you use.

Review

These are the important points you should have learned from this chapter.

1. In academic writing, you are expected to use information from outside sources to support your ideas. In addition to using quotations, you may also use paraphrases and summaries.
   - Paraphrase: Rewrite the author's meaning in your own words. Include all or almost all of the ideas that are in the original. Change the sentence structure and substitute synonyms where possible to avoid plagiarizing.
   - Summary: Condense a writer's words and summarize the main ideas in as few of your own words as possible.
2. Keep in mind that the U.S. system of education values students' original thinking and writing. Use outside sources *to support your own ideas*. Don't write a paper that contains only the ideas of others.
3. Don't just drop a paraphrase or summary into your paper. Make the connection between the borrowed information and your idea clear.
4. Document your sources to avoid plagiarizing and to help the reader find the sources of your information.